How News Becomes News — Workflow and the Newsroom

Olasunkanmi Arowolo

2026

Contents

Lesson Video 1

Transcript 1

Check-in Form: *Not provided*

© 2026 Olasunkanmi Arowolo. All rights reserved.

Lesson Video

QR unavailable

Scan the QR code at left to access the course video.
(Screen reader: YouTube video link is not provided)

Video: *Not provided*

Transcript

Source Metadata

Source File: `MCM202_Podcast_E02_Script_v1.txt`
Document Type: Podcast Script
Display Title: How News Becomes News — Workflow and the Newsroom
Source URL: Not provided

Document Text

```
MCM 202 Audio Series | Episode 2
Title: How News Becomes News --- Workflow and the Newsroom
Source: How News Becomes News: Workflow & Editing Explained - MCM 202 Lecture 2
Target duration: 20-24 minutes
Date drafted: 15 April 2026

---------------------------------------------------------------------------
PRODUCTION NOTES
```

Tone: Structured and purposeful, with energetic teaching bursts.
Delivery: Confident and clear. The workflow is step-by-step --- mirror that in your pacing. Let each stage land before moving on.
Music cue: [INTRO MUSIC FADES IN] just before the cold open.
[MUSIC FADES UNDER] when speaking begins.
[MUSIC OUT] by the first full sentence of the cold open.
[OUTRO MUSIC] after the action close.

Notation key:
[PAUSE] = deliberate 1-2 second pause
[SLOW DOWN] = reduce pace, let the idea settle
[ENERGETIC] = lift energy, pick up momentum
// italics // = emphasis word or phrase
[beat] = very short micro-pause, less than 1 second

[PRE-OPEN HOOK - 35 seconds]
[NO MUSIC YET. DRY. CLOSE MIC.]

A reporter files a story. [PAUSE] The facts are correct. The quotes are real. The event happened. [beat] By the time it reaches your phone the next morning, three people have touched it. [PAUSE] At least one of them has made a decision that changes what you // think // about the story. [beat] Not the reporter. Not the editor. [PAUSE] The person in between. [beat] The person most readers have never heard of. [PAUSE] In this episode, you are going to learn exactly who that person is --- [beat] and why // everything // depends on them.

[INTRO MUSIC - 10 seconds, then fade under]

SEGMENT ZERO: COLD OPEN
[30-45 seconds]

Welcome back to Editing and Graphics of Communication in Practice --- the MCM 202 Audio Series. I'm Ola. [PAUSE] Every day, breaking news happens somewhere. A policy is announced. A fire breaks out. A court delivers a verdict. [beat] And somewhere in a newsroom, a journalist starts writing. [PAUSE] But the story does not go from their keyboard to your phone. Not directly. It has to survive a process --- a structured, quality-controlled process --- before it reaches you. [PAUSE] This is Episode 2. Let's get into the newsroom.

[MUSIC OUT]

SEGMENT ONE: LESSON PROMISE
[20 seconds]

By the end of this episode, [beat] you will be able to explain how content moves through the newsroom step by step. You will be able to identify the role and core responsibilities of a sub-editor. And you will be able to apply basic editing corrections to a flawed news copy --- the way a sub-editor does it every single day.

SEGMENT TWO: CORE TEACHING --- PART 1
"The Newsroom Workflow: Five Stages Between Event and Audience" [4-5 minutes]

Let me ask you something. [PAUSE] Imagine a breaking news event is happening right now, right where you are. [beat] How does that information get from a reporter's notebook to your phone screen? What processes does it pass through before it gets to you? [beat] Does it get there by magic? [PAUSE]

Of course not. [ENERGETIC] News is not magic. It is a // structured process //. [PAUSE]

We call it the newsroom workflow. [SLOW DOWN] The newsroom workflow is the structured process through which news content is created, reviewed, and published. And it is built around one non-negotiable standard: that what reaches you is original, correct, accurate, clear, and timely. [PAUSE]

There are five stages. Let me take you through each one.

[ENERGETIC] Stage one: // News Gathering //. This is where it all begins. The journalist goes out into the world --- they attend events, conduct interviews, analyze documents, and collect information from sources. The challenges at this stage are real: incomplete information, tight time frames, the need to filter out personal bias even as events are unfolding. What emerges from this stage is raw material. It is not yet a news story. [PAUSE]

Stage two: // Drafting //. The journalist writes an initial version. At this stage, they focus on getting facts down correctly, structuring the information logically, and reaching for clarity. The common problems here are grammar errors, poor structure, and missing context. [beat] The reporter is not expected to be perfect. [PAUSE] That is exactly why stage three exists.

Stage three: // Sub-Editing //. [SLOW DOWN] This is the first major control stage. The sub-editor takes the reporter's draft and reviews it, refines it, checks it. We will spend the bulk of this episode on this stage --- because this is where most of the editorial work happens.

Stage four: // Editorial Review //. The senior editor reviews what the sub-editor has passed up. This is the final control stage --- focused on alignment with editorial policy, legal risk, ethical standards, and news value. Here is the critical reality: the editor's trust in the sub-editor is significant. If something slips past the sub-editor, it is likely to make it through. [beat] Which makes the sub-editor // the most important checkpoint // in the entire process. [PAUSE]

Stage five: // Publishing //. The content is released to the audience. Print, broadcast, digital, online --- depending on the medium and the platform. And this is where the story reaches your phone. [SLOW DOWN] Errors at this stage affect public trust. You cannot recall a published story the way you recall a product from a shelf. The damage is immediate, visible, and lasting. Whatever was not caught before this stage is now part of the public record. [PAUSE]

So when I say: Reporter Sub-editor Editor Publication --- I am not asking you to memorize a diagram. I am asking you to understand a system of // accountability //. Built specifically because real mistakes have real consequences. [PAUSE]

[EDITOR'S EYE --- recurring segment]
[~60 seconds]

Time for this episode's // Editor's Eye //. [PAUSE]

A reporter submits a story to you as sub-editor. When you open it, you see three problems: poor grammar throughout, a weak headline that tells readers almost nothing, and facts in the second paragraph you cannot immediately confirm are accurate. [PAUSE]

Question: what is your // first // step? [beat] And why? Think before I answer. [PAUSE]

Do you correct the grammar? [beat] Grammar errors are fixable at any point. They are important, but they are not urgent in this exact order.

Do you rewrite the headline? [beat] No. The headline matters --- but you need to verify the story before you commit to a title that might misrepresent it.

// You verify the facts //. [PAUSE] That is always the first step.

[SLOW DOWN] Because unverified facts, once published, cannot be unpublished. Bad grammar embarrasses you. Unverified facts can end careers, damage organizations, and misinform entire audiences. [PAUSE]

Accuracy before style. Truth before craft. Every time.

SEGMENT THREE: CORE TEACHING --- PART 2
"The Sub-Editor: Role, Responsibilities, and Skills" [4-5 minutes]

So who exactly is the sub-editor? [PAUSE]

A sub-editor is a professional responsible for refining content before publication. They sit between the reporter and the editor --- the critical linkage in the newsroom chain. When a reporter finishes writing and hands over copy, the first person they hand it to is the sub-editor. [PAUSE]

Think of the sub-editor as the quality control officer of the newsroom. Not the most visible person. Not the one whose name appears on the byline. But the most important checkpoint. [PAUSE]

Their core responsibilities cover six areas. [ENERGETIC]

One: // Edit for grammar and clarity //. Ensure the writing is clean, sentences are clear, meaning is not lost in structure. But as we just established --- this is important, not first.

Two: // Fact-check content //. Verify statistics, confirm names and titles, cross-check dates and places. This is at the heart of sub-editing.

Three: // Ensure consistency with style guides //. Every serious media organization has a house style --- rules about capitalization, how to handle

numbers, how to abbreviate, which titles take capital letters and which do not. The sub-editor enforces this standard across all content, all writers, every day. [PAUSE]

Four: // Write headlines and captions //. In many newsrooms, the sub-editor writes the headline. That is an enormous responsibility. The headline is what most readers see first. And as we discussed in Episode 1, the headline is not neutral. It is a frame. The sub-editor who writes a headline is making an editorial decision about how millions of readers will interpret a story. [PAUSE]

Five: // Detect legal and ethical risks //. Before a story reaches the editor, the sub-editor must ask: could this expose the organization to a defamation claim? Does naming this person this way cause unjustified harm? Are there ethical violations --- confidentiality breaches, sensationalism disguised as news, exploitative use of imagery? These are questions that belong at this stage, not after publication. [PAUSE]

Six: // Quality assurance on the complete piece //. The sub-editor is the last person who can stop a bad story before it reaches the final decision-maker. Their job is to ensure that what goes up is worth publishing. [PAUSE]

Now --- what makes a sub-editor genuinely excellent? [SLOW DOWN]

Four qualities define this. First: // attention to detail // --- an uncommon, almost relentless attention to what is actually on the page versus what should be. Second: // strong language skills // --- because you cannot fix what you cannot see. Third: // critical thinking // --- questioning not just grammar but logic, argument structure, and evidence. And fourth: // ethical awareness // --- understanding that every editorial decision carries consequences beyond the page. [PAUSE]

None of these are glamorous. But all of them are essential. [beat] If you are heading into journalism or media, the sub-editor's desk is where editorial instinct is built. Do not underestimate it. Do not skip it.

[NEWSROOM SNAPSHOT --- Nigerian context]
[~90 seconds]

// Newsroom Snapshot //. [PAUSE]

The copy arrives. A reporter has filed a story about a new federal government education policy. The opening sentence reads: "The federal government yesterday announce that they is planning to introduce a new education policy that will improve student performance across Nigeria." [PAUSE]

You are the sub-editor. Track Changes is on. You begin. [ENERGETIC]

First issue: "announce" should be "announced" --- wrong tense in a past-tense report. Second: "they is planning" --- subject-verb disagreement and an awkward construction. Change to "plans to introduce." Third: "federal government" as a proper noun requires capital letters --- Federal Government. Three issues in one sentence. [PAUSE]

Second paragraph: "The Minister of Education stated that the policy are focused on digital learning and teacher training." Another error: "the policy are focused" --- pick either "the policy focuses" or "the policies focus" and apply

it consistently throughout the story. Fourth issue caught. [PAUSE]

Final paragraph: "Students in rural area is mostly affected by these challenges." Two problems: "area" should be "areas" --- and "is" should be "are." Fifth and sixth issues. [PAUSE]

[SLOW DOWN] This is the work. This is literally what a sub-editor does with their time. Not glamorous. Not visible. But // necessary //. Because if any of those errors reach publication, the organization looks careless. And careless organizations lose trust. [PAUSE]

This paragraph is a real teaching example from MCM 202 practical sessions. That means these errors were written, submitted, and needed to be caught. The question is always the same: would you catch all of them? Every time?

SEGMENT FOUR: CORE TEACHING --- PART 3
"Digital Editing: Track Changes and What It Replaces" [4-5 minutes]

For most of journalism's history, editing happened on paper. With a pen. With a set of standardized marks --- symbols that every editor and typesetter could read and understand. [PAUSE]

These editing symbols are not arbitrary. They are a // shared language //. A stroke through a letter means delete. The caret --- the ^ sign --- means insert something here. A circle around two letters means transpose their order. When every editor in a newsroom uses the same symbols, the communication between them is precise, fast, and unambiguous. [PAUSE]

We will cover the full editing symbol set in detail in Episode 5. But for now, understand this: their purpose was always the same. // Clear, unambiguous correction instructions //. Same purpose. Same principle. Right up to today. [PAUSE]

Today, we edit digitally. Microsoft Word. Google Docs. And the tool that has largely replaced the red pen is // Track Changes //. [SLOW DOWN]

Here is how it works. Open your document. Go to the Review tab at the top. Click Track Changes --- toggle it on. When it is active, every change you make is recorded. Deleted text appears with a strikethrough. Inserted text is highlighted. Every correction is attributed to the person who made it, with a time stamp. [PAUSE]

The original author --- or the senior editor --- can then go through those changes one by one. They can accept each one. They can reject each one. Or they can accept all changes at once. [beat] The document becomes a // conversation // between the reporter and the sub-editor. A professional record of editorial decisions. [PAUSE]

You have four viewing options you should know. [ENERGETIC] // All Markup // shows every tracked change in full. // Simple Markup // shows a clean version with small flags indicating where changes exist. // No Markup // shows what the finished piece looks like if all changes are accepted. And // Original // shows you the raw draft before any editing was done. [PAUSE]

[SLOW DOWN] Knowing how to switch between these views is practical. Reading the piece in No Markup mode after making your edits gives you a clean final

read --- and that second read usually catches the error your first pass missed. [PAUSE]

This is not just a software skill. In any professional newsroom --- print, digital, broadcast production --- fluency with Track Changes is expected. Learn it now, before you need it in a professional setting. [PAUSE]

[SYMBOL CHECK --- recurring segment]
[~45 seconds]

// Symbol Check //. [PAUSE]

Today's symbol: the // caret // --- written as ^. In manuscript editing, the caret means // insert //. You place it at the point in the text where something needs to be added, and write what should be inserted above or beside it. [PAUSE]

Example: if a sentence reads "The government education launched plan" and a caret is placed between "government" and "education" with the word "new" written above it --- the corrected sentence reads "The government launched a new education plan." [PAUSE]

In digital editing, Track Changes handles insertions automatically. But when working on printed manuscripts or typewritten copy, the caret remains the standard insertion marker. Know it. Use it correctly. [PAUSE]

The full symbol set builds in Episode 5.

MICRO-ACTIVITY
[~90 seconds]

Pause here. [PAUSE] I mean that literally --- pause this episode and take two minutes before continuing.

Open a Word document or any text editor. Type out the following paragraph exactly as written --- errors and all:

"The minister of education stated that the government are planning to introducesa new policy. many school in lagos does not have adequate computers. Student in rural areas is the most affected by this challenges."

[PAUSE] Before you turn on Track Changes --- read through it slowly. How many errors can you find? [beat] Count them. Do not start to fix yet. Just identify and count. [PAUSE]

Then turn on Track Changes and correct every error you found. Accept all changes. Now read the clean version. [PAUSE]

That is sub-editing. And the practice of // reading before correcting // --- identifying every problem before attempting to fix any of them --- is one of the most important editorial habits you will develop. [PAUSE]

Done? Let's continue.

CHECKPOINT QUESTION
[~60 seconds]

Checkpoint question for this episode. [PAUSE]

A sub-editor receives a news story that has grammar errors, a weak headline, and several statistical claims that cannot immediately be confirmed as accurate. [beat] What is the // correct first priority //? [PAUSE]

A --- Correct all the grammar errors throughout the article
B --- Rewrite the headline to make it more engaging
C --- Verify the statistical claims against credible sources
D --- Check the word count and trim the article to length

[PAUSE] Hold your answer. Think about what the sub-editor's core responsibility is. Think about what happens when unverified facts reach publication. [PAUSE]

The answer is // C --- verify the statistical claims //. [PAUSE] Because unverified facts, once published, cannot be unpublished. Grammar errors embarrass. Factual errors are dangerous. A weak headline can be strengthened in five minutes. A false statistic in a published story can take months to repair. [PAUSE]

If you answered A or B --- go back and re-listen to the Editor's Eye segment from this episode. That principle is examinable.

RECAP
[~60 seconds]

Three things to take from this episode. [PAUSE]

[SLOW DOWN] One: The newsroom workflow has five stages --- news gathering, drafting, sub-editing, editorial review, and publishing. The order is not arbitrary. It is a quality control system. And errors that survive the sub-editing stage have a high probability of reaching your audience intact.

Two: The sub-editor is the critical control point of the newsroom. Their responsibilities cover accuracy, clarity, consistency, legality, and ethical safety. The single most essential quality they need is // attention to detail //. Not glamorous. Essential.

Three: Digital editing today runs through Track Changes. The tools change. The principle does not. Whether you hold a red pen or review a marked document on screen --- the sub-editor's job is to communicate corrections // clearly, precisely, and consistently //. [PAUSE]

The newsroom depends on this. Your audience depends on this.

ACTION CLOSE
[~30 seconds]

```
---------------------------------------------------------------------

Before you go. [PAUSE] Your assignment for this episode: find a published news
article from any Nigerian newspaper or news website. Identify three things a
sub-editor should have caught before publication --- and at least one must be a
factual or verification concern, not just a grammar or punctuation issue. Write
your observations in a short, focused paragraph. [PAUSE]

Episode 3 takes you directly into a live editing session --- how news is actually
edited before you see it. We work through real copy, real corrections, and the
decisions made in real time. [PAUSE]

I'll see you there.

[OUTRO MUSIC - fade in and hold]

---------------------------------------------------------------------
END OF EPISODE 2 SCRIPT
---------------------------------------------------------------------

EPISODE METADATA
Series: Editing and Graphics of Communication in Practice | MCM 202
Episode: 02
Script version: v1
Source files: How News Becomes News- Workflow & Editing Explained - MCM 202 - Lecture 2.txt
Estimated runtime at 135 wpm speaking pace: ~22 minutes
File naming convention:
 Script: MCM202_Podcast_E02_Script_v1.txt
 Record: MCM202_Podcast_E02_Record_v1.wav
 Final: MCM202_Podcast_E02_Final.mp3
```

Check-out Form: *Not provided*